

BLOCK 4
VOLUNTARY ACTION



UNIT 13 VOLUNTARY EFFORTS IN RURAL DEVELOPMENT

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13.0 AIMS AND OBJECTIVES

You must be aware that problems of rural society are multi-dimensional in nature. Therefore, issues and various aspects of rural development are also very complex. It requires multiagency and multi-dimensional approach to achieve its objectives. In this context the role of voluntary efforts becomes significant. After reading this unit, you will be able to:

- Conceptualize voluntarism and its evolution;
- Describe various types of voluntary organization;
- Differentiate between VOs and NGOs;
- Discuss the role of government in the promotion of voluntary efforts;
- Describe important features of CAPART;
- Explain the problems of voluntary organizations; and
- Suggesting efforts required for strengthening of voluntary efforts.

13.1 INTRODUCTION

It has been gradually realized that government alone cannot bear the responsibility of development of rural people and rural areas. It requires a lot of organizational and infrastructural support to activate/motivate human factors in the process of development. We are aware that voluntary efforts have always been an integral part of Indian social and cultural tradition. Thus it is deeply rooted in Indian society. As a consequence, voluntary efforts respond to the needs and aspirations of the society/community quickly and effectively. In this unit, efforts have been made to acquaint you with the concept of voluntarism, its evolution, types of voluntary organization, the differences between voluntary organizations and non-governmental organizations, governmental initiatives in its promotion, problems faced by voluntary organization and initiatives required to strengthen them.

13.2 VOLUNTARISM: EVOLUTION OF THE CONCEPT

Voluntary effort is an effort from one's own volition for the welfare of other fellow beings. It involves an active participation of people in the endeavour to enhance social and economic well-being of the community. Voluntary effort aims at helping people to help themselves by mobilizing their resources and tapping their potential to find collective solutions of their problems by implementing them to realize their goals. It is often the outcome of efforts of leaders and activists to mobilize people and motivate them to achieve certain growth-oriented goals. Voluntary effort need not always be in conformity or consistency with the current policies and programmes of the State. Quite a number of such voluntary efforts are of the nature of social activism in which individuals and groups organize themselves in protest against unjust national, state or regional policies and programmes which neglect issues of development, especially related to the marginal groups, and at the same time seek an alteration in the current social and economic systems and structures. Let us discuss some of the important features of voluntary effort.

i) People's Participation

In its true sense, people's participation implies participation of people at all stages, i.e. planning, programme formulation, implementation, decision making, sharing of benefits, monitoring and evaluation. Development programmes conceived and developed with people's participation are closer to the ground realities. Because they are rooted in the community and perceived as its own activity. People's participation is advocated on the ground with a view that it is a potent instrument for empowering people and bringing an improvement in the situation to make it sustainable. Sometimes voluntary effort is used interchangeably with people's participation. However, the two terms have much in common but they are not quite identical. Let us take an example to illustrate this. A group of people may

decide to work for the programme of adult education and set up a VO to undertake this programme. This will be regarded as a voluntary effort. The organization would plan programmes and map out the strategies. It may not involve the people in the process of planning, programme formulation and for developing tools of monitoring and evaluation. However, if the programme of the VO is to become effective, it will need the active participation of members and representatives of the community i.e. people's participation at all stages, from project formulation to evaluation.

ii) The Third Sector

In a societal context, VOs constitute the “third sector”, the first and second being the “government” and the “market” or private business. The “third sector” (VOs) is also known as the “independent sector” emphasizing the important role VOs play as independent force outside the realm of government and private business, though in financial terms, this sector depends heavily on both the government and private business.

The key factor that distinguishes an ordinary organization from a “voluntary organization” is the significant input that volunteers give to the management and operation of the organization. It is this factor that gives VOs the other commonly used name “non-profit” or “not-for-profit” organization (NPO). “Non-profit” or “not-for-profit” emphasizes the fact that the organization does not exist primarily to generate profits for its owners, managers or members.

Some VOs also prefix the term “private” and call themselves Private Voluntary Organizations (PVOs). Private, here, indicates that the organization is institutionally separate from the government. Hence, government-formed organization like National Dairy Development Board (NDDB), Council for Advancement of People's Action and Rural Technology (CAPART) etc., do not fall under the PVO category. Some VOs like to call themselves non-governmental organization (NGOs). This is, once again, to emphasize that the organization is not controlled by the government or any other outside agency.

iii) Features

Voluntary effort and people's participation are often institutionalized through the setting up of a VO. You may have by now some notion of the features of VOs. Let us now try and enumerate them:

- VOs are formed through the initiative of persons interested in the welfare and development, particularly of the disadvantaged sections of society. These persons have a sense of commitment and dedication and are spurred by social consciousness.
- Membership of VOs is purely voluntary.

- While some VOs may have specific areas of interest, others have macro-level and more global objectives.
- VOs are neither formed nor run for profit-making.
- VOs are governed by their own set of rules and regulations and do not function under the administrative control of the government. Some VO, however, seek grants-in-aid from government for which they are required to fulfill certain conditions indicated in the grants-in-aid rules.
- Most of the VOs are registered under the Societies Registration Act of 1860 or similar Acts of the state governments. Such registration entitles them to receive grants-in-aid from the government.

Importance of VOs in promoting national development

Vos have been considered vital on the following grounds:

- VOs have a first-hand experience and knowledge of needs and problems of the community and resources at the grassroot level.
- VOs are closer to the people at the grassroots.
- The commitment and zeal of voluntary action accelerates development work.
- VOs provides services at a rate faster in striking contrast to the rigid bureaucratic system.
- The voluntary sector is more responsive and can operate with greater flexibility.
- Voluntary action is cost-effective as it does not have an elaborate bureaucratic set-up.

13.3 PEOPLE'S PARTICIPATION AND DEVELOPMENT

Participation necessarily means direct involvement of the people and not indirect involvement through representation. Participation must be understood in terms of participation in:

- i) Decision-making;
- ii) Implementation of development programmes;
- iii) Monitoring and evaluation of the programme; and
- iv) Sharing the benefit of development.

Participation in the context of development has two distinct interpretations as below:

- 1) Participation as an input to development.
- 2) Participation is a means for empowering the rural poor to play effective role in rural development.

Thus, participation is recognized as an intrinsic part of the process of development rather than merely as a tool of facilitation. We need participation, because, it helps to increase the acceptability and utilization of the services. It provides additional resources to a field continually facing resource scarcity as community is seen as an untapped resource base by which services can be extended particularly to meet the needs of the under-served. People's participation is essential because it helps in breaking down existing structure obstructing development and replacing it with social, economic and political structures that are considered incompatible with development.

13.3.1 Factors Determining People's Participation

The process of people's participation is based on three assumptions as given below:

- The people as a community know, feel and accept responsibility for their own development.
- The people tap and develop their own resources to meet their needs; this includes personnel and material resources, professional and traditional, etc. This also includes private and government endeavours, institutions and organizations, local, provincial and national;
- Primary focus is put by the people in their own problems, resources and action according to community priorities.

Now let us see the various stages involved in the process of people's participation.

- i) **Conscientization:** Conscientization means process of building critical awareness. It is founded on the principle that all men are free to free themselves from any form of situational problems – fatalistic or deterministic. It is about building critical awareness based on a deep humanistic concern for people. Those being exploited or subjected to inhuman conditions may reflect over the situation and assess their needs from their own perspective. The voices of the poor and oppressed should be listened to and respected. They may be facilitated to reflect over their predicament. Based on the realization of deep crisis, appropriate action may be taken to liberate from oppressive forces. Thus, conscientization is an awareness building education process through which human beings perceive, interpret, criticize, and finally transform their own environment. In the words of David Hillwood, "conscientization is an awakening of consciousness, the development of a critical awareness of a person's own identity and situation; a reawakening of the capacity to analyze the causes and consequences of one's own situation and to act logically and reflectively to transform that reality".
- ii) **Organization:** The next step involved in the process of people's participation is organization. Organization precedes action. Organization

is also a process in which the people come together with a common objective of solving their own problems. In this process, they identify their needs or objectives and rank them according to the priorities as all the needs cannot be met immediately. The means by which their needs can be easily met are also identified. The resources both available and required are identified. The type of action to be taken is also finalized. It is a process which provides for personal community integration and interaction.

It therefore entails the designing of appropriate organizational structure which is made of goals, tasks, resource relationship, etc.

- iii) **Action:** In the analysis we have seen the stages that precede action in the process of people's participation. Taking measure or action is the final stage in which the people are given a chance to achieve what they want to. Action in the context of rural development can be broadly categorized into three components viz.,
- a) Effective utilization of the available resources and services,
 - b) Demanding for the provision of more and better services, and
 - c) Creating better social structure.

13.3.2 Factors Affecting People's Participation

In the above analysis we have seen the meaning and the process of people's participation. Here an attempt is made to reveal the factors affecting people's participation in a democratic country like India. Among the many factors, we would like to present those identified in a National Seminar on Organizing the Unorganized Rural Labour held at the National Labour Institute, Delhi in 1984. According to this Seminar the following factors are inhibiting people's participation.

- i) The coercive power of the propertied class whose aim is not to relieve poverty; rather the country, to make sure that the incomes of the masses are kept low and social services restricted to them.
- ii) The complex relationship between the economic dependency of the poor in rich and the heterogeneity of the poorer sections of Indian society.
- iii) The in-built bias of the local law and order machinery to maintain the status quo.
- iv) The lack of supportive legislation and also non-implementation of the existing social legislations enacted in favour of the poor.
- v) A negative and repressive attitude of the lower echelons of the bureaucracy and misuse of legal and administrative power against the organizers of the poor.

Apart from these factors the "Will" of the ruling elite or the social leadership is very important in the process of development of the poor. It has been

opined that the present programmes of poverty alleviation need to be complemented by group ventures of rural poor and collective action by these sections. When the poor themselves become conscious, improve their educational capabilities and are organized, the objective of participative strategies for removal of poverty will be fulfilled.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: a) Use the space provided below for your answers.

b) Compare your answers with the text.

1) Justify, in your own words, factors determining people's participation.

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13.4 MAJOR TYPES, ROLE AND FUNCTIONS OF VOLUNTARY ORGANISATION

Types of Voluntary Organizations

According to the approach and functions, the VOs can be broadly classified into:

- i) **Welfare Organizations:** These aims at meeting the minimum needs of the community, like food, shelter and also for providing facilities like education, health, water, etc. Often these organizations are managed by religious institutions and charitable trusts.
- ii) **Relief and Rehabilitation:** The organizations which respond to the problems arising out of natural calamities (floods, drought, famine) and manmade calamities (fire, ravages of war, communal riots). Their functions continue till the victims are rehabilitated.
- iii) **Activist Organizations:** These are the radical form of organizations. The personnel involved in such organizations believe in social action. Their main function is to conscientize people and assist them in taking necessary actions to solve their problems.

The Role and Functions of the VOs

The country's social and economic problems are so vast and multifarious that the government administrative machinery alone cannot tackle them. The establishment of a self-reliant society implies that people's dependence on government can be curtailed. Moreover, the meaning of development has

become wider to encompass the involvement of 'humans. There is a stress on qualitative change. It includes the involvement of the masses in the process of decision-making in the economic, social, political and cultural spheres. In the rural development context, development particularly means not just a cluster of benefits given to the people in need, but rather a process by which a populace acquires a greater mastery over its own destiny. It is only such changes in economic life which are not forced upon from outside but arises through its own initiative from within.

In the light of the above, it can be said that VOs are the appropriate agencies for creating the right type of climate for change and development. One might even say that VOs have an edge over the government also because of certain characteristics described below:

- The VOs, being small and independent from bureaucratic and hierarchical constraints are flexible to a great degree. They can respond swiftly and efficiently to the local demands. Being based locally, they are aware of the local environment and are responsive to it. They can adapt their style of working to the changing rural conditions. They generally employ people from local areas who are familiar with the local conditions and problems.
- Voluntary agencies go in search of new needs or unmet needs, and after having discovered them struggle to meet them in their own way. They create public opinion and if necessary they get the State to act. They can play a meaningful role in three ways.
 - i) To catalyze the rural population towards developmental approach;
 - ii) Build models, experiment with new programmes and act as innovators; and
 - iii) Represent the people of the area by identifying the local needs and aspirations.

The VOs are supposed to be potentially superior to official agencies in three respects,

- a) Their workers are more sincerely devoted to the task of reducing the sufferings of the poor than government staff;
- b) They have a better rapport with the rural poor than government employees; and
- c) They have freedom to respond to the needs of people.

You may be aware of or can recall the important role played by the VOs in certain areas, like the following which require special attention:

- Arranging for proper wages to the landless labourers;
- Striving to stop humiliation and all kinds of exploitation of the Harijan families;

- Rehabilitation of the bonded labourers;
- Spearheading anti-dowry campaign, etc.

In the foregoing analysis you have seen the potential of the VOs mainly based on structural advantages. An unparalleled function of the VOs is involving people in the process of development.

13.5 VOLUNTARY ORGANISATIONS (VOs) AND NON-GOVERNMENTAL ORGANISATION (NGOs)

Voluntary Organizations (VOs) and Non-Government Organizations (NGOs)

The differences between the VOs and NGOs need to be clarified because a lot of confusion exists in reference to their meaning. Some authors include the NGOs under the blanket of VOs while others treat the NGOs as distinct from the VOs. This is mainly because both have one thing in common, i.e., voluntarism. In the context of rural development when we talk about the VOs, the NGOs are generally included. The differences, however, remain and cannot be overlooked. Let us briefly go through them.

Both the VOs and NGOs differ widely in respect to its objectives, methodology, study of functioning, legal status, socio-political orientation, and economic strength etc. VOs are largely independent of the government and are not profits making enterprises. VOs are largely controlled and managed by an association of citizens. However, NGOs are different from other organizations of the state. The NGOs to be eligible for funding from various agencies, it should have legal status.

13.6 INITIATIVES OF NGOs AND VOs FOR RURAL DEVELOPMENT

A wrongly prevalent view that the VOs and the governmental agencies function as parallels needs to be rectified. In fact, the government in its attempt to solve rural problems used to assist and facilitate VOs and NGOs. Thus collaborations are required to make the process of rural development effective. States can create a conducive environment for a healthy relationship through following policy measures:

- Social policies should strive to build a healthy civil society;
- Public accountability of state institutions;
- Taxation policies – providing incentives to VOs;
- Regulation to help and facilitate VOs;
- Elimination of corruption, restrictive laws and procedures;

- State's collaboration with voluntary organizations having a proven track record. This way VOs remain true to their agenda and accountable to their constituencies;
- Offering a role to VOs in public consultations, invitation to their leaders to serve on official commissions, dissemination of information and so on;
- State should frame mechanisms of coordination on the basis of mutual respect and not dominate unnecessarily the voluntary sector;
- Provision of state funds on the basis of performance without compromising the independence and autonomy of the voluntary sector; and
- Assisting in the training of manpower required by voluntary organizations.

13.6.1 State Assisted NGOs: CAPART and CSWB

We have already discussed that both VOs and the NGOs are performing the same functions in the context of rural development. Let us study a typical case of an NGO, i.e., CAPART and CSWB to find out what are the areas of focus for the operation of NGOs.

- 1) **The Council for Advancement of People's Action and Rural Technology (CAPART)** The main focus of CAPART is to introduce new appropriate technological inputs for rural development. It acts at the national level as a coordinating agency for generating and dissemination of technologies relevant to rural development.

One of its main functions is to act as catalyst for development efforts and pilot projects of different agencies and institutions particularly voluntary organizations. It also plays a major role in organizing, guiding, developing and coordinating projects/schemes aimed at all round development and creation of employment opportunities, promotion of self-reliance, generation of awareness and improvement in the quality of life of people in rural areas. Besides these, CAPART is also entrusted with the task of carrying out a special scheme for organizing the beneficiaries of anti-poverty programmes. This scheme was conceived as a Seventh Plan Scheme by the Department of Rural Development, Government of India.

Administration: The scheme is monitored at three levels. At the central level the scheme will be executed through CAPART which will process the project proposals.

At the State-level, it could be implemented through other identified model non-governmental agencies. At the district and village levels the scheme would be implemented through institutions such as Nehru Yuvak Kendras, Voluntary Organizations, Mahila Vikas Kendra, and National Service Volunteer Corps.

Target Groups: The groups will be formed of families living below the poverty line from the following:

- a) Agricultural labourers;
- b) Bonded labour;
- c) IRD beneficiaries;
- d) Rural artisans;
- e) Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribes;
- f) Labour on NREP and RLEGP Schemes; and
- g) Small and marginal farmers.

Strategy: The strategy of implementation will be broadly in three stages.

Stage-1: The organizers will be identified from various non-governmental agencies/organizations such as those mentioned above. The organizer would be given intensive field training at various training institutions/agencies identified by CAPART. The training institutions and trainees will be identified by these non-governmental organizations/agencies involved in planning and implementation of rural orientation camps with support from CAPART.

Stage-II: The organizers will conduct awareness camps for beneficiaries at the block and village levels. The participants at those camps will be groups of beneficiaries, the organizers, the training institutions, public and non-governmental agencies and village-level government officials. The aim of these awareness camps will be to raise the level of consciousness, augment knowledge of schemes and create awareness about the benefits of group formation and action among the beneficiary groups.

Stage-III: This stage will comprise regular meetings of the group and contact with various agencies and wings of the government. It will be a continuing process which will ultimately culminate in the emergence of cohesive groups. The organizer, during these regular meetings, will create conditions to see that the leadership of the group is thrown up from within the group itself. Functional groups woven around a common economic activity have a better chance of success, and therefore, such groups should be encouraged. Ultimately, it is expected that these groups will become self-reliant.

2) Central Social Welfare Board (CSWB)

It is the major state funding agencies which provide grants-in-aid and other forms of support to registered VOs and NGOs working in the field of welfare and development for women and children. It functions under the administrative control of the Department of Women and Child Development; Government of India. Its State level Advisory Board served as its wings in State/Union Territories. It has nationwide network for the implementation of programmes in the areas of women literacy, micro credits to poor women,

formation of Self-Help Groups, employment and income generation activities, gender sensitization, fight against atrocities on women and girl child.

13.6.2 Voluntary Organizations (VOs)

There are large number of voluntary organizations working in the field of rural development and they have significant achievements in bringing awareness, people's mobilization, self-reliance and sustainable development. etc. Some prominent among these are as follows:

- 1) **Hind Swaraj Trust** – Anna Hazare's motivation created an unprecedented self-mobilization of local community to bring sustainable development Ralegan Siddhi.
- 2) **Self Employed Women's Association (SEWA)** – It strived to integrate poor self-employed women with mainstream economy through the twin strategies of struggle and development. The contributions of SEWA bank and its innovative integrated approach to micro credit for the poor self-employed women is significant.
- 3) **Professional Association for Development Action (PRADAN)** – It's contribution is significant in demystification and scaling down of technologies for comprehensive benefit of rural people.
- 4) **Social Work and Research Centre (SWARC)** – It has been successful in imparting sustainable development to rural communities in Tilonia, Rajasthan. SWARC has demonstrated that formal education or professional degrees are no more essential requirement in the process of rural development.
- 5) **Tarun Bharat Sangh (TBS)** – It has created a national awakening in rural communities about the value of existential linkage with natural resources for them. TBS has rejuvenated water harvesting structures in drought prone areas of Rajasthan. TBS has successfully imparted socio-economic prosperity, Self-Reliance and solidarity among rural communities in and around Bheekampura.
- 6) Thus, we can conclude that both the VOs and the NGOs have a common objective of the development of the rural area by involving the community and helping them to be self-reliant. The NGOs provide the necessary link between the VOs on the one hand, and the government on the other, to facilitate the achievement of development programs. It is significant in the ultimate analysis that VOs, the NGOs and the government are all working towards the same goal.

Check Your Progress 2

- Note:** a) Use the space provided below for your answer.
b) Compare your answer with the text.

- 1) Distinguish voluntary organization and non-governmental organization.

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13.7 PROBLEMS OF VOLUNTARY ORGANISATIONS

- You should not get the impression that because of the official policy of promoting and supporting voluntary effort and allocating funds to different ministries for grant-in-aid to VOs, their problems have been satisfactorily resolved. This is far from truth. In spite of the grants-in-aid now available to a large number of VOs, a majority of them still face an acute problem of lack of financial resources which hampers their functioning. At times, lack of financial resources may not be as severe a constraint as lack of assured funds on a continuing basis. Because of this problem, some VOs are forced to give up an activity half way through and pick up another for which funds are available. Some VOs depend heavily on foreign funds which are uncertain. Funding agencies have their own perceptions and often impose their priorities and programme designs on the VOs. Ad hoc grants from government or aid agencies tend to reduce them to faceless bodies running a variety of unlinked programmes. This threatens both continuity and expansion.
- VOs also face leadership problems. As the VOs expands the area and scope of their activities, some prominent personalities often begin to assume overriding powers in running the organization. Taking initiative and making decisions become the prerogative of a few at the top. This increasing centralization affects flexibility of functioning, hampers democratization of decision-making and obstructs the emergence of new leaders and team-work thereby gets compromised. The views and concerns of younger members of the organization are often overlooked and even suppressed. This gives way to groupism within the organization. Quite a few VOs suffer from the absence of a second line of leadership. The process of decision-making and style of functioning do not indicate a plan to build leaders, and to inculcate healthy organizational norms.
- It has also been seen that not many VOs pay adequate attention to build the target group's capacity to change and develop, and identify their own leaders. The lack of efforts to develop viable organizations of the rural poor is one reason why despite the presence of NGOs and VOs for several decades, grassroots organizations have not really come up.

Absence of good grassroots VOs affects genuine empowerment of the poor.

- A low salary structure and inability to provide a career ladder limits the ability of VOs to recruit and retain qualified and trained staff needed for several types of activities. Paid workers of VOs often have a mixed set of attitudes; some are genuinely interested and committed while others perceive this as an interim arrangement till a better alternative emerges. The absence of a career ladder results in a larger turnover. This naturally tends to affect the functioning of the VOs.
- Poor maintenance of records and accounts and lack of attention to organization-building through maintenance of records and accounts. There is also a lack of administrative and technical competence to prepare project proposals and apply for grants.
- Uneven development of voluntary effort in different parts of the country is yet another constraint. In fact there seems to be no relation between the size of the state or its population and the number of active VOs. Several parts of the country, particularly the backward areas, suffer because of the absence of VOs which can utilize funds allocated by the government for implementing schemes through such organizations.
- Despite the official policy of encouraging voluntary effort, VOs do not get real support from the bureaucracy and political leaders. From the point of view of the VOs governmental agencies, including those at the district level and below, are not willing to shed their power and monopoly over the development programmes. They claim superior knowledge and expertise in the implementation of rural development programmes. Barring some exceptions, the attitude of these government agencies toward VOs is apathetic. They do not treat the VOs as equal partners in the process of large programme implementation. At the national or state levels there may be the best of understanding among them, but at the grassroots level, the relationship is not always promotive. The style of functioning remains bureaucratic and there is an expectation that VOs will show their obeisance in the corridors of power to get grants. The unfortunate result is that genuine grassroots level organizations get discouraged and are not able to procure grants. A large number prefer not to depend on government funding. In recent years there has been a tendency for several spurious organizations to be set up with the objective of getting grants from government which are often siphoned off or diverted for other purposes. Through their clout they are able to get grants even though these organizations exist only on paper. Adverse publicity about them has a fall out on the genuine organizations as well. It is now quite well known that several politicians and political parties use VOs to promote their own interests. This has become a matter of genuine concern.

There were moves, both official and non-official, in the mid-1980s to set up a Voluntary Council of India and have a Code of Conduct for Voluntary Organizations. This was expected to help in the formulation of a coordinated policy, facilitate selection of agencies for government funding, prevent misuse of funds, and safeguard the rights, privileges and interests of the voluntary sector, specially the smaller agencies. The idea, however, ran into strong opposition from several voluntary groups as it was feared that this would lead to control and regulation of the voluntary sector and, increased bureaucratization, thus adversely affecting the functioning of organizations working with marginalized groups.

13.8 STRENGTHENING OF VOLUNTARY ORGANISATIONS

Now that you are familiar with the role of VOs, their strengths, and some of their problems, you should also know some of the measures that could be taken to improve the situation. In this section we will take a look at the suggestions for promoting and strengthening voluntary effort. After going through them, you can see if you can add some of your own.

- The leaders should, through word and deed, promote voluntary effort. Industrialists, professionals and the academic community should demonstrate their commitment in this regard. This will give them much greater insight into the development problems of the poor.
- There should be a radical change in the manner in which the bureaucracy deals with VOs. An extension oriented promotive style of functioning is very important to accomplish the objectives.
- Grants-in-aid programmes should be widely publicized among VOs and assisted in applying for these grants since many of them have little experience in this regard.
- The flow of grants-in-aid is affected if there are no agencies to take them. Hence special effort at promoting voluntary effort should be made in those states or areas where voluntary agencies are non-existent.
- The system of grants-in-aid should be streamlined and simplified. Grants must be released in time as delays create problems in providing services and paying the staff.
- VOs must make a conscious effort to improve their own organizational structures and administrative competence, including accounts and housekeeping.
- They must develop competencies of volunteers in the relevant subject matter for problem solving and motivational techniques .

- Continuous efforts should be made to motivate and build capacity of the community.
- There must be greater coordination among NGOs and VOs to avoid duplication of services. A Coordinating Council of Voluntary Organization will be useful for providing a forum for collaboration and co-operation and jointly taking up issues of concern with the government.
- A clear training policy must be implemented by VOs as motivation is not enough. A professional approach is always able to achieve better results.
- The larger VOs should develop appropriate personnel policies for the staff.
- Programmes of VOs must be documented and widely disseminated so that society is in a better position to assess their endeavours. This would also serve as resource material for others.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: a) Use the space provided below for your answer.

b) Compare your answer with the text.

- 1) Briefly discuss the problems faced by voluntary organizations.

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13.9 LET US SUM UP

Voluntary effort has a critical role in development as it shows how vibrant a society is trying to solve its own problems. In this unit, we discussed the concept of voluntary effort and its main features. We saw how VOs differ from NGOs not only in the matter of their origin and sponsorship, but also in terms of their funding, autonomy, style of functioning etc. We have also acquainted you with various initiatives of VOs and NGOs for rural development. In this context, we have dealt with state assisted NGOs like CAPART and WCWB and VOs like Hind Swaraj Trust, SEWA, PRADAN, SWRC and TBS. We noted that the main source of strength for voluntary effort are commitment and dedication, flexibility and ability to respond to local needs, close interaction with the community and innovativeness. VOs, however, have to face problems in terms of funding, concentration of decision-making in the hands of a few, unattractive service conditions of paid staff, apathy of the bureaucracy, and tendency of politicians and others to use VOs for personal or political gain.

13.10 KEY WORDS

- 1) **Extension Education:** It refers to non-formal education meant to educate/train/inform farmers/people in the community to bring desirable change in their behaviour. This knowledge may be in areas such as agriculture, animal husbandry, health, etc. Extension education has a promotive and developmental approach for building the capacity of the target group.
- 2) **Memorandum of Association:** A Memorandum of Association is drawn up for the registration of a society under the Societies Registration Act.
- 3) **NGO:** Non-Government Organization. VOs are also NGOs but not all the NGOs are VOs. Some VOs are also initiated, sponsored, and constituted by the government.

13.11 SUGGESTED READINGS

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UNIT 14 VOS/NGOS: FORMATION AND ADMINISTRATION

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14.0 AIMS AND OBJECTIVES

This unit aims at acquainting you with the formation and administration of VOs/NGOs. After reading this unit, you should be able to:

- Understand the processes of formation and registration of VOs/NGOs;
- Explain the importance of strengthening of VOs/NGOs;
- Discuss important features of administration of VOs/NGOs; and
- Describe the needs and process of staff development.

14.1 INTRODUCTION

You are aware that voluntarism and social services have long history in India. It was an important source of welfare and development from ancient period. After independence, voluntary organization influenced by Gandhian philosophy dominated the scene in India. In the previous unit, we have already discussed how voluntary agencies are non-governmental in nature and these are run and controlled by a group of people. They work with different social groups i.e., SCs and STs, Women, Senior citizens, disabled etc. and on various issues like pollution, environmental concern, wild-life protection, water harvesting etc. which are of great societal relevance. These agencies also provide inner strength and consciousness among these disadvantaged groups so that they can protect their interests and rights.

In this unit, attempt has been made to provide you overall picture and detailed information related to formation and administration of VOs and NGOs.

14.2 FORMATION OF VOs/NGOs

The constitution of India guarantees its citizens right to form association under Article 19. The provision is operationalized with the help of legislations such as the societies Registration Act, 1980 (or similar state Acts). A group of people associating themselves, as a society on registration under any of these laws, become a separate legal entity whose legal identity is distinct from its constituting members. Registration entitles members to many privileges and exceptions. Some VOs prefer not to register themselves to avoid government's scrutiny and fulfillment of the conditions stipulated under the Act concerned.

It would always be desirable for any agency to have a constitution, giving the aims and objectives, organizational structure, membership, mode of election etc. Therefore, VOs/NGOs require its registration.

14.3 NEED AND PURPOSE FOR REGISTRATION OF VOs/NGOs

Need for Registration of VOs/NGOs

The need to register a group or association as NGO/VO are many, as detailed below:

i) Establishing and Managing

Any group of likeminded individuals can come together to form an association or a society and get registered under the appropriate law of the land to gain legal identity and standing. Also, VOs operating in social systems can establish and maintain contact with several individuals. In general course, the community also interacts with the organization and not each member individually. Thus, it is imperative that the organization is an important entity which can be created by giving it a legal basis. The individual liability now becomes group liability. Registration under appropriate law, depending upon the nature of activities of a group of individuals will help in giving the status of an organization.

ii) Finances

Availability of financial resources is most important factor for efficient functioning of VO and implementation of its programmes. Now a days, there are several partners besides the government to provide aids and grants for development such as corporate bodies, national and foreign donor agencies etc. Since the VOs essentially fulfill social objectives and developmental role, the government has responsibility to provide financial and technical

assistance to them. While seeking governmental grants and other financial assistance, one of the essential prerequisites for the same is registration. An organization must be registered under appropriate Act, or produce certificate that it is regularly constituted branch of that organization. It should also maintain regular accounts and proper audit statement. The other donor agencies, most importantly foreign agencies, also disburse funds to registered organizations.

Thus, registered organizations can seek funds from three main sources: government sources, corporate and other bodies and foreign donors. Foreign funding agencies are categorized under the following:

Bilateral funds

Bilateral funds refer to the funds for NGOs available with countries that have come into bilateral agreements with India. Earlier, foreign funds used to be channelized through the Government of India but after 1972 foreign groups pressurized their governments to give a portion directly to NGOs in the Third World.

NGO donors

Usually NGO groups and charity organizations, Examples – OXFAM, Action Aid, Save the Children Fund etc.

Sponsors

Groups like Action Aid help in sponsoring the programmes concerning the children.

iii) Tax Deduction

Section 80(G) of Income Tax Act enables an individual or company to avail a deduction of 50 per cent of their donation to VO accredited by the tax authorities from taxable income, provided the donation exceeds Rs. 250/- (two hundred and fifty only) and is less than 10 per cent of total income in that year. This has opened the floodgates for many NGOs as the donor group is exempted from being taxed for that sum. It has also enabled the organizations to bring in more locally available resources.

iv) Foreign Contribution Regulation Act, 1976

VO needs to be registered and be operational for three years before it can get FCRA (Foreign Contribution Regulation Act, 1976) number and thereby receive funds regularly from foreign agencies. Also, the VOs have to be non-political so that the funds are not used by any political party. The Home Ministry of the Government of India issues and administers these certificates after determining eligibility through reports from government field agencies who seek information directly from the organization or through enquiries at the community level. The Foreign contribution Regulation (Amendment) Act, 2020 prohibits foreign contribution for any activities that pose a danger to national interest.

v) To Address Problems of Functioning

Any group or body of persons, can come together to form a Society and start functioning. However, registration assumes significance in this collective endeavour to do away with problems that might arise in future. These issues may range from internal dynamics amongst the members to the external functioning in the community. Besides laying down aims and objectives in the Memorandum, the registration also spells out the process of internal management viz. membership, subscription, rights and privileges of membership, general body – its powers, duties and functions, managing body, sub-committee, sources of income and utilization of fund, audit of income, operation of bank accounts etc.

Any modification in the constitution can be made only subject to the approval of the Registrar providing protection to members in internal functioning and also to the organization as an entity.

B) Purpose

The main purpose of VO is to work for the betterment of a particular target group with a committed focus and efficient delivery. The initiatives may cover a range of social issues like education, health, culture, socio-economic activities like trade union activities, development of co-operatives, self-help groups etc. Financial resources and infrastructural support available for functioning largely determine the broad purposes of the organization. Besides, orientation and experience of the organization in the specific field also play a crucial role in framing its purposes.

C) Organizational Accountability

The VOs have to be accountable for their activities and report to the authorities about the proper use of funds, subsequent to acquiring registration. They also have to register with the income tax authorities to seek income tax exemptions on the grants they receive and also separate registration for the foreign funds they receive.

The main distinguishing features of VO are:

- 1) It is registered under an appropriate act to give a legal entity to a group of individuals and also to transform the individual liability to group liability. Some of the acts under which organizations can be registered are: **The Societies Registration Act, 1860; the Indian Trusts Act, 1882; the Cooperative Societies Act, 1904; the Joint Stock Companies Act, 1956** or any similar act; but most of the welfare agencies are registered under Societies Registration Act (XXI of 1860).

(The following associations may be registered under Societies Registration Act (XXI of 1860): ‘Charitable societies, the military orphan funds, societies established for the promotion of science, literature or the fine arts, for instruction, the diffusion or useful

knowledge, the foundation or maintenance of libraries or reading rooms for general use among the members or open to the public or public museums and galleries of paintings and other works of art, collections of natural history, mechanical and philosophical inventions, instruments, or designs.’)

- 2) It has an administrative and executive management committee.
- 3) The organization must have declared a set of objectives, including quantitative ones. It should be based on keen appreciation of ground realities and should be the end result of genuine consultation among all the members involved. It should have its own democratic principles, rules and procedures that govern the internal functioning of the body and should not have an external control.

The significance of registration of an organization is due to the fact that the community perceives it as one legal entity and considers dealing with one body more rewarding than interacting with different individuals. Besides, such a group of individuals will be more sustainable and ensure effective delivery of service. An organization in a longer run would be better equipped to deal with various complexities rising out of daily functioning and management.

Constitution and Bye-laws/Memorandum

The objectives of the organizations have to be broadly defined in the constitution by indicating the duties, powers and functions of the various parts of the organization. Besides the constitution, the organization also draws up the bye-laws or the detailed rules and regulations governing the day-to-day functioning. A constitution can be understood as a brief statement spelling out the broad goals and objectives of the organization, often including the quantitative goals too. It may not include the detailed procedures to be followed for the attainment of these objectives; which are incorporated in the bye-laws. Bye-laws are needed for the following reasons:

- Smooth functioning of the organization
- Division of the roles and responsibilities
- Stability of the group

14.3.1 Registration of a Trust – Process

Formation of an organization as a Trust is fairly simple but the provisions, procedures and the laws related with trust are fairly complex. Under Indian Laws various kinds of private and public trust can be formed. Laws and procedures related with a Public Charitable Trust with reference to The Indian Trust Act, 1882, is not applicable to Public Charitable Trust. Public Trusts are formed under general law. The other relevant acts are Religious Endowment Act, 1863, Charitable and Religious Trust Act, 1920 and The Bombay Public Trust Act, 1950.

Essentials of a Valid Trust

The following are the basic ingredients of a valid trust:

- i) The author or settlor of the Trust
- ii) The Trustee
- iii) The Beneficiary
- iv) The Trust Property
- v) The purpose of the Trust

Who Can Form a Trust?

Any person competent to deal with property can create a trust. Besides Individual, a body of Individuals or an Artificial Person such as an Association of Persons, an Institution, a Limited Company, a Hindu Undivided Family through its Karta, are eligible. Three certainties of a trust are:

- i) Certainty of intention to create trust.
- ii) Certainty of the objects and the beneficiaries.
- iii) Certainty of the subject matter of the Trust i.e., funds or properties must be specified and settled in the deed.

Charitable Purpose

To form a Public Charitable Trust, it is important that the objectives of the trust is of charitable nature and of general public utility. The Charitable Endowment Act, 1890 defines charitable purpose as a purpose for the relief of the poor, education, medical relief and advancement of any other object of general public utility but does not include a purpose which relates exclusively to religious teachings or worship.

Since it is necessary for a trust to be registered under the Income Tax Act, it is important to understand the meaning of 'charitable purpose' as per the Income Tax Act. The term charitable purpose has been divided into 4 parts:

- i) Relief of Poverty
- ii) Education
- iii) Medical Relief
- iv) General Public Utility.

Procedure of Formation of a Trust

No clear-cut statutes are available for the formation of Charitable Trust. The only Central legislation available is The Charitable and Religious Trust Act, 1920. This act is limited in its applications, and does not provide any effective control over Public Charitable Trusts. To form a valid Public Charitable Trust, it is always desirable to prepare a Trust deed. Such Trust deed should clearly specify and satisfy the certainties of a trust.

Meetings and Resolutions

Sound governance largely depends on the effective interactions between the decision-making persons of the organizations. It is very important that regular meetings are conducted for:

- Decision-making
- Planning and Budgeting
- Resource mobilization
- Legal Control
- Appointment of Auditor
- Purchase of Capital Accounts
- Appointment of staff, etc.

Registration Process

Non-Governmental Organization or voluntary agency does not begin and end with simply filing application. The registration under the Societies Registration Act, 1860 entails following points:

1) The Form

The form is available from the Office of Registrar in State capitals. (Guidelines and instructions for completing the form are included.)

2) Filling up the Form

Any group of seven or more members desirous of working for any charitable purpose or cause may, by subscribing their names to a memorandum of association and filing the same with the Registrar of Societies or any other officer appointed under the Act by the state Government can form a society.

The Memorandum of Association should contain the following particulars:

- a) Name and address of the association
- b) Purpose
- c) Membership requirements
- d) Other particulars

3) Legal Assistance

The filing and subsequent registration at the Office of Registrar involves drafting of the Memorandum and Rules and regulations in a way that protects both the members and the organization from legal issues and difficulties that may arise in future. Also, all suits by or against the society shall be commenced or defended in the registered name of the society. Thus, it is advisable to take legal assistance in the process of formulation of the document and filing it to the Registrar.

4) Final Stage

The organization would file with the Registrar of the Societies, a memorandum showing the name of the society, its objects, names and address and occupations of the members of the governing body accompanied with rules and regulations and a copy of proceedings of the general meeting at which it was resolved to get the society registered.

The Memorandum prepared in this format and signed by seven or more members sponsoring the organization would be submitted to the Registrar with the prescribed fee. He would record the name of the society under the Act and issue the certificate of registration. The registered body would have to submit the annual list of managing committee members and other information as required by the Act to the Registrar. Upon registration, all properties, movable and immovable, will become the property of the society and all suits by or against the society will be commenced or defended in the registered name of the society.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: a) Write your answers in the space provided below.

b) Compare your answers with the text.

1) What is the purpose or need to register VOs or NGOs?

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2) Briefly describe the process of registration of voluntary organizations or NGOs.

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14.4 ADMINISTRATION OF VOs/NGOs

14.4.1 The Design Stage

General Meeting

A General Meeting of a VO is a meeting of all the members of the organization. Normally only one general meeting is held in a year to discuss and approve important matters like approval of audited accounts, appointment of auditors, and review of activities during the year. This meeting is called Annual General Meeting (AGM).

Board Meeting/Governing Body Meeting

The meeting of the governing body of an organization is held more frequently to take administrative decisions. Normally one such meeting should be held in every three months. The governing body meetings are very important for the management of an organization.

Notice

A notice of every meeting is required to be given in writing. Care should be taken to provide for the length of the notice while framing the bye-laws of the organization.

Agenda

Along with the notice of a meeting; it is desirable to enclose agenda or the list of items to be discussed.

Quorum

The term quorum implies the minimum number of members that must be present to make the proceedings of a meeting valid. Normally the bye-laws of an organization specify the quorum required for different meetings.

Proxy

Proxy refers to a person or a representative empowered to attend a meeting on behalf of a member. Any member of an organization who is entitled to attend and vote at meetings is also entitled to appoint a proxy. The proxy has to carry an authorization in writing in a proxy from the members entitled to attend the meeting.

Minutes

Minutes are the formal record of the proceedings of the meeting. It is important to record the summary of the proceedings of the meeting in a written form. A minute's book can be of loose sheets chronologically bound together or a bound register. The pages of the minutes should be consecutively numbered. All the members are required to sign in an attendance register during the meeting. The members can also sign in the Minutes.

Resolutions

A resolution is a formal expression of the decision taken by the members in a meeting. It is required to specifically mention the decision or opinion in the shape of a resolution along with the number of members voting in favour and against that particular resolution.

There are two kinds of resolutions:

- i) General Resolution where a simple majority is required to pass,
- ii) Special Resolution, where a higher percentage of support is expected to pass the resolution.

14.4.2 Planning and Budgeting Stage

Planning is the most important part of a project; it is the stage of conceptualization and laying down of the future agenda in a potentially feasible seed form. This task may involve the following factors though it is a highly subjective issue:

- Generation of ideas
- Scouting for project ideas
- Preliminary screening of ideas
- Feasibility of promising ideas
- Survey of facts and figures
- Financial analysis – developmental returns
- Economic analysis – cost/benefit in the organizational context
- Ecological analysis – environmental impacts
- Technical analysis wherever necessary
- Determining overall worth of the project
- Preparation of funding proposal.

Financial Planning

All the planning exercise has to go hand in hand with the requirement and availability of funds. All the projects and programmes have to be conceived in financial terms. The financial aspect of planning is broadly known as budgeting.

A Project/Program entails various kinds of expenditure such as:

- i) Capital expenditure
- ii) Expenditure on programmes
- iii) Administrative costs.

A project may require various kinds of financial outlay over the entire life of the project. A project or programme may range from less than one year to six or seven years or more. It is very important to understand that one has to plan and anticipate both the receipts and the payments required at each stage, during the entire life of the project.

Capital Expenditure: Capital expenditure in common parlance is an expenditure of enduring nature. In other words, it refers to an expenditure whose utility is not limited to a small period of time but years. Planning of a project generally involves planning of capital expenses over a period of time. Therefore, it is very important to understand the importance and the problems involved in taking decision regarding such expenditure.

Importance: Decisions about capital expenditures are considered important because of the following reasons:

- Enduring effect
- Cannot be reversed
- Huge investment

Problems: Whenever decisions about capital expenditure are required to be taken, the following problems generally arise:

- Measurement problems
- Uncertainty
- Spreading the project over assets life

Budgeting: A budget is the financial translation of a project plan. All the planned expenditures and receipts are estimated as per the budget and consequently the feasibility of a project is judged. Budgets have two aspects:

- i) The sources of funds
- ii) Activities and expenses

Budget is a very important tool of financial management. It helps in estimating in advance the probable receipts and payments and in comparing the variances after the completion of the project activities. In other words, budget is the financial parameter on the basis of which the project activities are conducted. After completion of the activities the actual expenditures are compared with the budgeted expenditure, the variances help in understanding the need for improving the system in terms of budgeting as well as implementation.

14.4.3 Implementation and Stabilization Stages

Let us now see the points to be kept in mind at implementation and stabilization stages.

Administration at Implementation Stage

The administrative process at the implementation stage is primarily conditioned by the agency's need to establish clientele and constitute a system of reciprocal relations with groups and organizations in the environment. At the same time, addition of staff to work in the agency introduces an element of accountability in the agency's performance and a need to find ways to effect greater consistency, co-ordination, and control.

It is necessary to build programme competence, define service domain and reduce uncertainty in inter-agency and intra-agency relations at this stage. Three major tasks in this regard are:

- Attracting clientele and establishing rapport with the community and other agencies;
- Structuring the agency so as to promote efficiency, co-ordination and accountability; and
- Developing appropriate policies for personnel selection and development of staff competence.

Some of the general principles to be observed during the implementation stage are:

- Consult and involve local people at every stage.
- Give sufficient notice.
- Explain the purpose clearly and repeat it as often as necessary.
- Have the meeting conducted by local people as far as possible.
- Record the proceedings in a way that everyone will understand and agree.
- Assign follow-up work.
- Reconvene meetings at short intervals.
- Keep participation open.
- Get the first activity inaugurated formally so as to attract attention widely.
- Use simple words and symbols familiar to the community.
- Make the outcome of the activity/benefit tangible, immediate and appropriate.
- Employ local people as far as possible, employment of outside professionals being resorted only to the extent absolutely necessary.
- Keep the number of staff employed at the minimum to reduce the incidence of continuing liabilities.
- Use local know-how.

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- Keep expenses to the minimum and avoid ostentious expenditure at all costs.
- Have openness in communication between members of the staff and between agency and the community.
- Devise simple procedures and forms that are based on trust.
- Promote self-confidence.
- Issue instructions which are clear, and take care to see that it should be possible to carry them out.
- Observe time schedules and encourage its observance.
- Select beneficiaries on the basis of rational criteria derived from the objectives of the program.
- Encourage staff and volunteers to learn and build teamwork.
- Exercise close supervision in a matter which is promotive and builds confidence.

Administration at Stabilization Stage

As an agency enters the stabilization stage, the question of survival is no longer a matter of prime importance. Well settled rules, regulations, job specifications and performance standards are the hall-mark of a stable agency. Staff maintenance at this stage is concerned with the kinds of supervision and leadership that will promote satisfactory levels of performance and job satisfaction.

At the stabilization stage, the effectiveness of agency should be assessed and regular channels for accountability established. The cumulative effect of external demand for effectiveness on the morale of the agency staff will have to be moderated with the help of buffering and neutralizing mechanisms.

Development of a proper monitoring system of programme implementation is also a major area of concern.

Innovations and improvements can be introduced as a device for maintaining high morale and accountability. Procedural, programmatic, and basic change can be initiated. The exact shape, nature and procedure of introducing change should be decided on a participatory basis. At this stage, choice of issues for response, choice of persons to be involved and other matters need to be considered. The basic philosophy of the agency should determine the choices availed. Thus, stabilization stage is not a static stage. On the other hand, it is at this stage when the agency enjoys a secure position that attention can be given to development and innovation.

14.5 STAFF DEVELOPMENT

All agencies now need to recruit paid staff as well. The recruitment, retention, and development of staff has been one of the major problems faced by VOs. Under the banner of voluntarism, VOs expect their paid staff to render dedicated and self-less service with unattractive salaries and service conditions. Those who join these VOs are often forced to accept such conditions as they do not have a better alternative. In some cases, ad hoc responses play a decisive role in the matter of creation of posts and appointments. As a result, VOs face problems in administering programmes. Staff development has been one of the low priority areas of VOs. Let us take a look at some of the important aspects of managing personnel.

Type of Personnel Needed

The type of personnel needed will be decided according to the goals, objectives and the kinds of programme of the organization. They are usually of two types viz., administrative personnel and programme personnel.

Recruitment

Most of the VOs do not follow proper recruitment procedures. This affects their functioning. For recruitment to be effective, it is necessary to frame the recruitment rules, setting out the qualifications, mode of recruitment, scale of pay, etc. A job description is also necessary. Vacancies then to be announced. The selection process starts with the screening of applications, short-listing the candidates, conducting a written test if necessary, constituting a selection committee, interviewing the candidates and making the appointments. Usually, a panel of names is drawn up in order of merit and appointment letters are sent accordingly.

Performance Appraisal

Performance appraisal is the systematic assessment of the strengths and weaknesses of an employee's performance of assigned tasks during a specified period.

Training

Training is now recognized as an investment in staff development. It not only increases knowledge, understanding and skills but also provides better motivation. Voluntary agencies are now called upon to implement a wide range of programmes and engage in some degree of social engineering as well. Workers have constantly to interact with people, communicate with them and function as change agents. Training helps not only in career development and efficiency of the employees, but also improves the agency's performance.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: a) Write your answer in the space provided below.

b) Compare your answer with the text.

1) Discuss the financial planning involved in VOs or NGOS?

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14.6 LET US SUM UP

In this unit, we first discussed the meaning and scope of voluntary agency administration. We saw that the principal administrative tasks are planning and developing the programmes, acquiring resources, designing organizational structures and processes, developing and maintaining staff capability, and assessing and changing agency programmes. We also considered the different types of activities that arise from these tasks.

We stated that voluntary agencies typically evolve through several stages overtime, each of which is characterized by a set of administrative tasks. Each stage poses different problems and dilemmas and demands differential attention. The three stages of change and development are design stage, implementation stage and stabilization stage.

Design stage is the initial stage of development. It commences with conceptualization of an idea, identification of a need/problem/issue. This stage is marked by a preoccupation with translating the concern/policy into concrete programmes of action and in getting legal recognition of the agency as an independent entity.

The implementation stage commences as the agency swings into operation. Scheduling day-to-day activities, devising various procedures and channels of communication to promote efficiency, coordination and accountability, negotiating exchanges, recruiting and placing staff are major administrative preoccupations at this stage. Stabilization stage is concerned with assessing the activities of the agency, instituting changes where change is required, maintaining other activities of the agency, ensuring continuity of the agency, and resolving conflicts. We saw that staff development which is generally neglected by voluntary agencies has to be an important area of concern. Recruitment, performance appraisal and training need careful attention for improving the agency's performance and the motivation of the staff.

14.7 KEY WORDS

Elites: Influential section of a population.

Non-recurring expenditure: Expenditure which does not recur, i.e., incurred once.

Recurring expenditure: Expenditure which recurs, i.e., incurred often.

Staff development: Identification of manpower needed in relation to activities to be performed, salary structure, and recruitment, appraisal of performance, promotion/career ladder, and training.

Voluntary agency: An autonomous non-governmental organization formed by persons out of their own volition

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UNIT 15 DEVELOPING COMMUNITY BASED PROGRAMMES AND PROJECTS

Contents

- 15.0 Aims and Objectives
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- 15.2 Meaning
- 15.3 Planning Community Based Programmes
- 15.4 Programme Formulation
- 15.5 Working with Community Groups
- 15.6 Let Us Sum Up
- 15.7 Key Words
- 15.8 Suggested Readings

15.0 AIMS AND OBJECTIVES

This unit aims at familiarizing you with the process and methods involved in developing programmes and projects that are community based. After reading this unit, you will be able to:

- Outline the concept of community based programmes;
- Indicate the steps involved in identifying community needs;
- State the process of identifying beneficiaries and resources; and
- Describe the principles of working with communities.

15.1 INTRODUCTION

While planning and developing rural development programmes, the government or a voluntary agency may follow different approaches. You have seen that very often government schemes and programmes are prepared at the state capital and are handed down to district and block level for implementation, following the same schematic pattern. Such programmes usually end up by remaining government activities as the beneficiaries themselves are neither involved nor have access to planning/decision-making processes and systems. There is little scope for flexibility to make changes in response to local needs. We see today passive dependence on government initiatives and the implementation of programme according to the government's perception of what is good and necessary for the community. The people, for whom these programmes are meant, participate only as beneficiaries.

In this unit, we shall discuss how to develop a rural development programme that is community based. First, we shall analyse the meaning of a community based programme. Secondly, we shall learn how to plan a community based programme. Finally, we shall discuss the processes involved in formulating a programme followed by a brief analysis on the techniques in working with the community.

15.2 MEANING

The term community has already been discussed and is not unfamiliar for you. You may recall from Block 1 of Course 1, that a community is a group in which the members live in such a way that they share the basic conditions of a common life. A community has a territorial base, a strong sense of identity and deep sense of togetherness. One's life may be lived wholly within it. One's social relationships may be found within the community.

A community based programme does not necessarily connote a programme which is universal in its coverage and aims to benefit all or most of its members. It implies a programme that is planned, initiated, sustained and implemented with the participation of the community. In other words, it connotes people's involvement and participation at every stage. A programme organised by an outside agency, even if it is a Voluntary Organization, will not be community based if it does not follow the above criteria.

The assumptions behind community based programmes are the following :

Bottom-up Planning

There are limits to the extent to which outsiders can have insight into the problems of a community. Local people too have capabilities in planning, activating and involving the cross-section of the community in broad-based decision-making, using a consensus-based approach and team-work in implementation. It is essential that the creativity of the total community is mobilized for effective developmental process.

Need-Based

The planning of community based programmes should stem from the needs of the community. There may be some needs which are felt by the community. There may be others which have not been identified by the community but which experts feel are critical for the community, for instance, environmental sanitation and preventive health. In such cases it would be necessary to sensitize the community to such needs.

Local Resources

However scarce the local resources may be, their mobilization and utilization are essential. Local resources can be in the form of money, material or manpower. Availability of local resources can not only draw funds from

outside but also help in the sustenance of the programme when such outside funding ceases.

Participation

Participation by the community is critically important because it initiates further action through democratization of decision-making. Participation is the keystone for effective work. Involvement of local people brings local knowledge and expertise into use and thus reduces unnecessary dependence on technocrats and outsiders. It empowers people to take action collectively.

15.3 PLANNING COMMUNITY BASED PROGRAMMES

The process of planning plays a vital role in the development of community based programmes. Community organisation practitioners use planning skills, but too often these skills are seen as being narrow and technical, creating a gap between the planner and the people. Time after time, you will find that as a practitioner you will be called upon to draw a representative group which can be involved in goal determination, programme development, programme implementation and evaluation. Since planning precedes action and forms the basis for the other stages of community-based programmes, in this section we shall discuss the various steps required for developing them.

Approaching the Community

The first step in planning a community-based programme is to 'enter' the community. Very often, when an outside agency 'enters' a community it creates speculation and suspicion in the minds of the local people. Hence, 'entry' into the community is to be planned very carefully. The following are some of the ways of entering the community.

Meeting Community Leaders: If possible, the community leaders are identified before deciding how and when to approach them. In a community, generally two kinds of leadership exist, viz., formal and non-formal. The former is elected or chosen by the community through a formal prescribed procedure, as for example, the *pradhan/sarpanch* of the Gram Panchayat. The latter can be a teacher or religious leader or others who, by virtue of their social, religious or other factors come to be regarded as leaders. The community worker must meet both types of leaders and try to explain the purpose of meeting and win their confidence.

Preparation of the Community: At this stage the community leader assisted by the community worker introduces the idea of starting a community-based programme to the members through meetings and discussions. The broad purposes are discussed and doubts/anxieties clarified. In order to foster wide acceptance, all groups are invited.

Community Diagnosis: Though the problems and needs of the community might emerge in community meetings and discussions, it is often difficult to assess their magnitude and their complexity. A properly planned survey, designed through community participation conducted by a trained person will provide a better perspective on the community problems. While this could lack the rigour of social science research, it would nonetheless give a reasonably good factual picture. This would help not only to know about the conditions of the community and to assess the needs but also enable local leaders and the people to be better informed about their conditions and the problems faced by them. The following guidelines can be used for community diagnosis through a sample survey :

- decide the objectives of the survey.
- determine the principal areas of inquiry.
- prepare a simple schedule suited to local needs and adapted to the skills of the interviewers.
- make known to the leaders the purpose and the reasons for collecting data.
- select the interviewers from the local community and give them a brief orientation and training in collection of the information.
- gather the information through the schedule and through interviewing people who are in a position to give information on some key areas.
- tabulate the data.
- write up the report.

Need Identification

If the results of the survey are disseminated in the community, it can generate a lot of interest, discussion and activity and pave the way for identifying programmes needs.

Community meetings and informal exchanges with members would also help. It is not feasible to tackle all the problems simultaneously. At the same time, the question arises as to which need or needs are the most important because it is desirable to begin a programme with a relevant activity important to a significant number of people. Therefore, the process of how to prioritize the needs assumes importance. The following steps can be followed:

Presenting the problems to the community: The problems identified are reported back to the community in a form understandable to them. It can be presented orally or in writing. Oral presentation to community leaders provides a good opportunity for discussion of the major problems identified by the survey and expressed in community meetings as well.

Determining the criteria: Some of the criteria which can be used to identify problems requiring immediate attention and action are the incidence and gravity of the problem, groups primarily affected, the number of persons affected, the importance that the community places on tackling the problem, and the likely consequences if the problem is not tackled immediately.

Choosing problems to work on: As we have mentioned earlier, it is not always feasible to work on all the priority problems simultaneously. Nor is it easy to have unanimity or to reach at a consensus. Usually, the problems chosen are the ones which are the most pressing as perceived by the majority and which are amenable to local solutions given available resources and the resources that can be mobilized. In some cases the following procedure can be followed:

- The priority problems are presented to the key members of the community with an explanation as to how these were identified. Ensuring active involvement of the key members is important as it would make the decision-making process more easy and meaningful and increase their commitment to the programme.
- The members of the community are asked to rank the problems as most immediate, immediate, not immediate.
- The problem which is identified as most immediate by most member scan be selected for priority action.

An alternative method is to let the key members talk among themselves, decide, and then inform the community. The first method is preferable for evolving a consensus through discussion and debate. It is necessary in either case to ensure that powerful interests do not dominate and the interests of the disadvantaged and the women are safeguarded.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: a) Space is given below for your answers.

b) Compare your answers with the text.

1) How are programme needs identified?

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2) How would you approach an unfriendly if not hostile community?

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(Hint : See the text which describes the usual method. Use your knowledge and experience or those of others and write down the steps for cases such as the above.)

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15.4 PROGRAMME FORMULATION

In the previous section, we have seen how to select or prioritize problems which need immediate action. In this section, let us discuss the various processes involved in formulating an action plan or a programme.

Before going into the process of formulating a programme or project proposal let us look at the kinds of policy and inter-organizational issues that need to be considered:

- 1) Which are the major groups, organizations, institutions concerned with the problem? What is the nature of interaction between these groups and what are the forces impelling or preventing them from working together?
- 2) Which parties/groups have been identified as sources of support or opposition?
- 3) What general approaches have been used?
- 4) What are the major material and non-material resources available locally? What are the pre-conditions and how are they monitored?
- 5) What resources are currently being used for coping with the problems?
- 6) What alternative solutions could be developed that may be acceptable?
- 7) What is the outcome expected by the community?

Setting Objectives

Having decided on the problems to be tackled, the objectives have to be clearly defined as a first step while formulating a programme. Objectives are derived from the goals which are stated in broader terms and have a longer time perspective. Objectives are precise statements of intentions that can be translated into pragmatic programmes. As far as possible, it is better to set a manageable number of objectives (not exceeding say four or five) which can be achieved within a reasonable time frame. When objectives are quantified in a time frame, these are called targets.

Determining Programme and Service Components

The objectives will determine the programme and service components. It is important that these are prepared in sufficient detail so that monitoring

becomes easy. Some of the aspects that need to be covered are determining the beneficiary groups, the criteria for selection of beneficiaries, the services that will be provided, the strategy for accessibility of the beneficiaries, the use of the services by them, and the delivery system.

Identification of Beneficiaries

Identifying the beneficiaries is an important but at the same time a very complex task specially when subsidies/loans or other forms of assistance are involved, or when local power structures wish this to be done in a manner which furthers their interests or does not empower others in a manner which will challenge their dominance. Quite often, evaluation of development programmes indicates that selection of beneficiaries was not done according to the criteria laid down for the programme. Various methods of selecting beneficiaries can be used. We mention some here:

- The survey helps to identify the beneficiaries.
- The official or agency entrusted with the task of implementing the programme prepares the list on its own by applying the criteria laid down in the scheme.
- Leaders of different groups are asked to suggest names.
- Selection is done through an open meeting in which all are asked to participate.

If any of the first three methods is followed and after the preliminary list has been prepared, it is best to discuss this in an open meeting so that ineligible persons can be identified and those who are eligible but were left out, can be included. This procedure is particularly important where subsidies or loans at a concessional rates or other benefits are involved.

Setting Milestones

Setting milestones means indicating the stages needed to accomplish the stated objectives goals. This is important in formulating a programme. The following points are to be considered:

- Select the tasks needed to accomplish the programme objectives.
- Identify the difficult tasks and the possible obstacles that might arise at the time of action.
- Decide on when each action is to be carried out.
- Identify the tasks that can be undertaken by members of the community and/or the possible ways in which the community can participate in implementing the programme.
- Assign responsibilities as to who will do what, and when. The stated actions can be written in the following format.

Goal Milestones Who will do it Target Dates

While specifying the actions needed for achieving the objectives, the agency must be very clear as to whether it is going to foster dependency on the part of the members of the community or they will be empowered with information with which they can help themselves in the long run. This is one of the important principles of developing a community-based programme.

Identifying the Resources and Preparing the Budget Estimate

The next step in programme formulation is the identification of the resources, i.e., resources available locally and those needed from outside the community. Given the economic conditions of rural village communities, expectation of financial contribution by the local people could be a sensitive issue. For example, when the majority of workers in a village community get a meager wage of say for example Rs. 50 per day only for a few months in a year, we cannot request them to contribute towards meeting the full or a significant cost of the programme. At the same time, in order to make them feel “we do our own programme”, it is essential that their contribution, whether in cash or in kind, is obtained even if it is meager. The resources of the community might include materials, equipment, funds, skills, technical knowledge and manpower.

A budget estimate has to be prepared indicating how much money is allocated and for what purposes. You have read in the previous unit about the functions of an agency’s budget. Before preparing a budget estimate, a realistic estimate of the extent of finances that can be mobilized is essential as there are some assured grants or incomes, and some which are somewhat uncertain. The budget estimate should be presented to the community. Over optimism about funds is not desirable, specially if there is the danger of the programme getting to bestopped midway. Similarly, for recurring expenditure, a long-term perspective of resource availability is necessary.

Planning Programme Implementation

The following aspects ought to be taken into consideration while planning for programme implementation with the objective of making the programmes acceptable to the community and achieving the desired goals:

- Finding able and willing local leaders to assume responsibility for launching the programme.
- Setting up committees, which will include representatives from the community, to supervise and review the programme.
- Identifying organisations within and outside the community to assist in the implementation of the programme.
- Dividing the tasks and assigning them to different persons and as far as possible involving members of the community to carry out the key tasks.

- Establishing a suitable recording and reporting system of the ongoing activities.
- Deciding on the type and number of beneficiaries to be covered initially.
- Ensuring the availability of finance at least for the first year.
- Finalizing the duration of the entire programme and the time required for each activity.

Check Your Progress 2

Note : a) Space is given below for your answers.

b) Compare your answers with the text.

- 1) Give an example of an objective and a target based on it.

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- 2) How can beneficiaries be identified ? Which method would you prefer?

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15.5 WORKING WITH COMMUNITY GROUPS

In the preceding sections, we have discussed the various processes of developing a community based programme. In our discussion we have seen that the nucleus of the community based programme is the participation of the community. In the first unit, we introduced you to the concept of community participation. Here we discuss some of the salient features of community participation.

Features of Community Participation

In Unit 1 of this Block, we introduced you to the concept of people's participation. Participation, as we saw, implies direct involvement of the people and involvement not through representatives. Participation must be understood in terms of participation in decision-making at all stages – planning, implementation and monitoring – so that the people can share in the benefits of development. People's participation in the context of rural development has to be seen not only as an input to development but also as a means of empowering the rural poor to play an effective role in rural development. For developing a community-based programme, participation of people has to be recognized as an intrinsic part of the process of development rather than merely as a facilitator.

Some authors are of the view that participation, in order to be broad-based and meaningful, would imply alteration in existing social and economic structures which are incompatible with equity. Conscientisation is often considered an important step in people's participation particularly for redressing or correcting inequalities and exploitation. Conscientisation in a simple sense means critical awareness-building. It is founded on the principle that all men and women are equal and that the learners, even the most oppressed, are capable of change and can free themselves from any form of existence which is fatalistic or deterministic. Among all the means of eliciting people's participation, conscientisation has gained wide prominence and acceptance. The work of the Brazilian educator Paulo Freire, 'Pedagogy of the Oppressed' has been widely discussed in this context and has made a profound impact on scholars and social workers interested in equality and justice for the deprived.

Critical awareness-building is based on a deep humanistic concern for people. This leads the people to assess their needs from their own perspective rather than those of the powerful who have made the poor mere tools in their hands for profit and power. It implies a reawakening of the capacity of the poor to understand and analyse the causes of one's situation and to act in order to be able to change the situation.

Types of Community Participation

As we have seen, community participation as a process involves a close interaction between the people and the functionaries. A number of ways exist by which people may join the planners and implementers and these can be assessed in terms of type of participation, its functions and location of power. As the community comes closer to decide its own life situations, the more successful will be the community-based the programme. We can think of six modes of community participation.

Modes of Community Participation in Planning and Managing Development Guidelines for Collaboration/Integration

Identity of participants	Focus of power	Functions	Assessment in terms of direct exercise of power by the people
1) Educated group (elite) appointed by outside authorities.	Government functionaries and local elite.	Legitimizes outside plan through local elites.	Community is minimally involved in decision-making.
2) Government functionaries such as Convenor of Village Development	Government functionaries and local elite.	Legitimizes outside plan through local elite and implementation of outside	Community is minimally involved in decision-making. People participate as followers or as

Committee		programmes is facilitated because local elites have authority from above.	recipients of benefits.
3) Government functionaries consult people after plans have been drawn up.	Government functionaries	Legitimizes outside plans by making people feel that they have had a say in the matter.	Consulting the community after the plans have been decided; allows a few genuine options of participation but only as a token.
4) Government functionaries consult people's groups from the beginning of plan.	Government functionaries and the people but the former have more power.	Allows a meeting of minds; gives people a more realistic understanding of planning need to establish priorities.	People's involvement from the beginning gives them a significant share in decision making; however, government functionaries still control the process.
5) One or two beneficiaries are represented on the Board	As beneficiaries are few in number, the Government functionaries being in the majority have a say.	Legitimizes the concept of people's participation; simultaneously it legitimizes outsiders' control	People share decision-making responsibility.
6) Local people beneficiaries are in the majority on the Board	People have a major say in the decisions	Legitimizes peoples' power and empowers people.	Empowering people provided they do not act as pawns of outsiders.

Guidelines for Collabouration/Integration

Fundamental to community-based work is integration and close collabouration between different organisations and persons. Formal integration involves merging of different services in a pre-determined way. Informal integration involves close working relations as it develops persons even though they do not belong to the same organisation.

Some of the practice guidelines are :

- Assume that informal networks exist.
- Expect formal/informal networks to exhibit varying characteristics.

- Beware of costs.
- Organise user-related information about formal/informal network.
- Encourage informal positive attitude towards formal/informal networks.
- Analyse information about these networks.
- Work in partnership with the existing networks.
- Work with network members' needs.
- Work with groups of users and volunteers.
- Protect staff from pressures.
- Encourage sharing of information.
- Decentralize decision-making and control systems.
- Consciously develop team members' skills.
- Formally identify link persons.
- Share resources.
- Arrange meetings with entire team.
- Encourage the entire team to take decisions.

Principles of Working with the Community

The following principles may serve as guidelines while trying to elicit community participation:

- ***Be focused:*** Clarification of goals and understanding of programme objectives is basic to working with community groups.
- ***Identify the Leaders carefully:*** Leadership is the single most important ingredient in successful community work and hence selection of leaders from the community should be thoughtfully and carefully done.
- ***Be prepared:*** Progress and movement of the programme is directly related to the adequacy of preparation before and after meetings in which decisions are made.
- ***Be involved:*** A climate of involvement of all members should be created for participation to being productive and effective.
- ***Build support:*** Support, and not supplant, the leadership.
- ***Communicate:*** Keep all members informed of the activities and developments at frequent intervals formally and informally.
- ***Be dynamic:*** Maintain a sense of progress, movement and accomplishment that is so essential for the morale and satisfaction of the community group.

Key Factors in Working with Community Groups

Let us now identify the key factors in working with community groups.

One should not get the impression that a community is homogenous, that all persons living in a community will participate in decision-making, that their participation will always be for the common good, and that no one will oppose a proposal, or that no one will enhance his self interest. More often than not, a community has factions, interest groups, competing and sometimes conflicting goals, and a power structure in which some groups or persons dominate.

Locating Centers of Power

Locating centers of power in a community is not an easy task. There are those who enjoy status because of the position they hold; there are those who have a high reputation; and there are those who have traditionally been participating in making important decisions in the community. There are various theories about power structure and locating centers of power in a community. Each group competes with others to corner as much benefits as possible. Each group will willingly and actively participate only if there are tangible benefits accruing to them. In the final analysis, it is inevitable that only few groups will participate actively.

The role of the community worker is to guide these groups and their participation in such a way that the interests of the poor and the vulnerable do not suffer.

Decision-making

Decision regarding development programmes are complicated. If decisions (not of a routine kind) are made by one person, it may be handicapped by limited information, experience and ideas. To reduce risk and to gain legitimacy, all major decisions are best taken by committees or in open meetings. Group decisions gain legitimacy because the group can be so composed as to have persons who bring to bear on the problem diverse frames of reference and viewpoints, and the group has a leader who facilitates this creative process.

Roles and Rules

All group processes involve a basic underlying structure – a framework that holds the group members together and partly accounts for order in their behaviour. Individuals who occupy certain positions in the group generally perform certain roles. These roles evolve in the group process through role differentiation. Rules in the group explain what action should be or should not be performed by members. Both roles and rules take time to evolve.

Techniques for Working with Groups

It is important to know some of the strategies/techniques for working in or

with groups and making the groups work. It is useful for the community worker to be aware of them to facilitate group functioning and to detect those that are not desirable. Let us try and list these techniques :

Technique	Definition
Reasoning	Any statement using rational arguments to influence others.
Expertise	Superior knowledge or skills or experience.
Compromise	Both community worker and target group give up a part of their desired goals in order to obtain some of them.
Bargaining	Explicit statement about reciprocating favours and offering other two-way exchanges.
Persuasion	Simple statements to induce, convince or coax into action.
Simple statement	A matter-of-fact statement of one's desires.
Persistence	Pursuing firmly; repeating one's point.
Assertion	Forcefully stating one's view.
Thought manipulation	Making the target think that the agent's way is the target's own ideas.
Fait accompli	Openly doing what one wants without avoiding the target.
Hinting	Not openly stating what one wants; indirect attempts at influencing others.
Emotion alteration	Agent attempts to alter emotions of target.
Threat	Stating that negative consequences will occur if the agent's plan is not accepted. He may occasionally use facial expression or body language.
Deceit	Attempts to mislead the target into agreeing by the use of flattery or wrong information or traps.
Evasion	Doing what one wants by avoiding the persons who would disapprove.

Conducting Meetings

In Block 4 of Course I in the Unit on 'Communicating with People', you learnt the principles and the methods of inter-personal communication. A meeting is a forum of inter-personal communication.

For a meeting to be conducted successfully, the composition, seating arrangement, frequency and the agenda have to be carefully designed.

There are some techniques of conducting a meeting which are also useful for

channelising the thinking of the group in the desired direction. Formal groups can be made to function effectively by observing the following formal procedures:

- Giving terms of reference and clarifications in writing.
- Specification of committees' authority.
- Limiting the size of the group to an optimum.
- Careful selection of chairperson.
- Appointment of a regular Secretary.
- Preparation and distribution of agenda, notes and other supporting documents several days before the meeting.
- Prescribing frequency of meetings.
- Ensuring punctuality in starting and ending the meeting.

For a smooth conduct of the meeting, the leader and the members also have to see that the objectives of the meeting are achieved. The leader of a Committee should :

- Control the garrulous.
- Draw out the silent.
- Protect the weak.
- Encourage diversity of ideas and alternative approaches even if they are conflicting.
- Watch for suggestions.
- Come to the most senior people first but at the same time give opportunity to all.
- Close on a note of achievement.
- Similarly, members should also state their position as clearly and logically as possible, and listen and ponder on others' point before their own point is pushed.
- Seek out an acceptable alternative if the discussion gets bogged down.
- Not to yield for the sake of harmony but accept a decision only if it is based on sound logic.
- Shun techniques that bypass logic merely for the sake of reducing conflict.
- Look out for different viewpoints and pull everyone to the discussion.

Leadership

The role of leaders in collective thinking, group decision making and in influencing others cannot be under-estimated. Leaders exercise influence on the group members and influence their behaviour. They are, in turn, influenced by them. This is a reciprocal process by which group members

permit themselves to be influenced and motivated to facilitate attainment of mutually satisfying goals.

Many factors such as the participation rate, characteristics of the group, nature of the task, and dynamics of the organisation contribute to improving interpersonal relation within the group and in helping the group successfully to complete its tasks. Leadership plays an important role in this regard.

The skills of the leader manifest in (a) communicating with people, (b) building credibility in himself and in his proposals, (c) locating dissent/opposition, (d) piloting the agenda, and (e) in persuading the group members to commit themselves to the objectives of the agenda. The external environment, situational stimuli, size of the group, its structure, and existence of factors which block the achievement of its goals, also influence the effectiveness of the leader.

Leaders are identified by finding from the members of the community the persons they consider as leaders in the matter of influencing or directing, or by asking the functionaries or other persons the names of persons who they think exercise leadership functions. The assumption here is that influence is not exercised in the same degree by every member. It is important to remember that influence is not exercised by most members of the community. In most cases however, this is of a very limited nature. In the case of leaders the influence is exercise among much larger numbers.

The identification of community or group leaders is, however, not always an easy task specially when there is likely to be some kind of a plurality of leadership and in some cases a hierarchy which is not necessarily formalized or structured. Sometimes leaders become identified when there is a crisis or when some important goal has to be achieved.

Some leaders are authoritarian in style – determining policies, indicating the strategy and plan of action, and assigning tasks. Community-based programmes demand a democratic style of leadership-sharing with members in policymaking and implementation, asking the members for alternatives, choosing the best course of action through participation and involvement, giving members the freedom to choose their responsibilities, and encouraging group thinking and decision-making. Sometimes the community expects the leader to direct and assume charge because it has not undergone the experience and strength of democratic or participatory leadership. With conscious efforts on the part of the leader, this can change and community participation can become effective.

Check Your Progress 3

Note : a) Space is given below for your answers.

b) Compare your answers with the text.

1) What does conscientisation imply?

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2) Can you list some principles of working with the community?

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3) How does authoritarian leadership differ from democratic leadership ?

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15.6 LET US SUM UP

We read in this unit that a community-based programme is one that is planned, initiated, sustained and implemented with the participation of the community and characterized by the involvement and participation of people at every stage. We noted that such programmes were need based, involved the use of resources and were not entirely supported from outside. We also described the ways of approaching the community, making community diagnosis and defining the needs. We considered the various processes involved in formulating a programme and discussed in this connection how objectives are determined, beneficiaries are identified, milestones are set, resources are identified, budget estimates are prepared, and programme implementation is planned.

We considered the features of community participation. We saw how the process of conscientisation or critical awareness-building was important for reawakening of the capacity of the poor to understand and analyse the cause of one's situation and act in order to be able to change the situation.

We considered various types of community participation and assessed them in terms of direct exercise of power by people. We also read about some of the practical guidelines for community-based work for collaboration and integration. We noted that among the principles of working with the community were the needs to be focused, identify leaders carefully, be prepared, be involved, build support, communicate and be dynamic. The key factors in working with community groups were also identified and the techniques of working these group were illustrated. We also considered the roles of leaders in community based programmes and their functions. We concluded that community based programme demanded a democratic style of leadership and sharing of decision-making with members in matters of policy and implementation.

15.7 KEY WORDS

Community: A group living in a geographical area having a strong sense of identity and a deep sense of togetherness. The members of the group share the basic conditions of a common life. All of one's social relationships may be found within the community.

Goal: A statement indicating what is sought to be achieved. Goals are usually expressed in a longer time perspective.

Leadership: This is defined in the context of the degree of influence a person exercise on other members of the group or community.

Objective: This is derived from the goal and is a precise statement of what is sought to be achieved.

Schedule: A questionnaire filled by an investigator from the respondent in a face-to-face situation.

Target: A quantified expression of an objective in a time frame.

15.8 SUGGESTED READINGS

Cox, F. M. , J. L. Elrich, J. Rothman and J. E. Tropman (1977), *Tactics and Techniques of Community Practice*, F.E. Peacock Publishers : Illinois.

Handley, R.M., M. Cooper, P. Dale and G. Stacy (1987), *A Community Social Worker's Handbook*, Tavistock Publications, London.

UNIT 16 SOCIAL ACTION

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- 16.1 Introduction
- 16.2 Meaning
- 16.3 Main Features
- 16.4 Social Action and Social Reforms
- 16.5 Strategies of Social Action
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16.0 AIMS AND OBJECTIVES

This unit aims at familiarizing you with an important method through which the deprived and the oppressed sections of society seek changes to achieve social justice. Social action has a long and chequered history even though its identification as a technique is a more recent phenomenon.

After studying this unit, you will be able to:

- Explain the meaning of social action;
- Describe its main features;
- Analyse the strategies;
- Discuss the tactics; and
- Describe some of the social action movements in India.

16.1 INTRODUCTION

Social action has been a part of the process of development of human society. There has hardly been any time in social evolution when people have not organized themselves and enjoined to protest against injustice, to seek redressal of grievances or alterations in unjust social, economic and political structures. The struggles that ensued did not always achieve their goals but they represented important expressions of deprived people's attempts to secure a more humane society. Social work education gave social action an academic status by recognizing it as one of the methods of Social Work and its inclusion in the curriculum of Master's degree programmes.

Voluntary effort and people's participation have been recognized as being critical to the success of any development endeavour and find a legitimate

place in almost all the plan documents and official policy statements. However, social action, as a tool to mobilize people for development work, is rarely mentioned in such documents probably because it represents to those in authority an organized endeavour to bring about changes which often results in conflict of interests with those in power who are sometimes opposed to such initiatives of change, overtly or covertly.

Social action is a very powerful instrument in the hands of the people to secure social justice and human rights. The foremost practitioner of social action in our country was Mahatma Gandhi. Social reformers, trade union leaders, public workers and political activists have been involved in social action movements in one way or the other. For all those who are interested in empowering people, this unit is therefore of considerable interest.

16.2 MEANING

There is currently no universally accepted definition of social action, though there is a broad understanding of it. We give here some of the more widely used definitions so that you have an idea of how different scholars have viewed social action.

One of the earliest definitions was by Mary Richmond (1922) who considered social action in terms of “mass betterment through propaganda and social legislation”. This definition however, is too general and fails to bring out the distinguishing features of social action.

A more elaborate definition is given by Friedlander (1963): “Social action is an individual, group or community effort, within the framework of social work philosophy and practice that aims to achieve social progress, to modify social policies and to improve social legislation and health and welfare services.” This definition, as you will see, rules out conflict or radical alternation when it prescribes action “within the framework of social work philosophy and practice”.

Roger Baldwin defines social action as “Organised effort to change social and economic institutions as distinguished from social work or social service, the fields which do not characteristically cover essential changes in the established institutions. Social action covers movements of political reform, industrial democracy, social legislation, racial and social justice, religious freedom and civil liberty; its techniques include propaganda, research and lobbying.” This definition does not specifically refer to social action as seeking change in a manner consistent with social work values. It seems to suggest, however, as will be evident from the methods it mentions, that the action for change will be within the parameters of the existing institutional framework.

Gabriel Brito brings out the ‘conflict’ element when he states that “Social action is a conflictual process of varying intensity initiated and conducted by

the masses or by a group of elites, with or without the participation of the masses in the action against the structures or institutions or policies or programmes or procedures of the government and/or relevant agencies and/or power groups to eradicate/control any mass socio-economic-political problem with a view to bringing betterment to any section of the under-privileged at a level larger than that of a sociologically defined community”. This definition brings out also the role of leaders from outside the affected groups initiating and conducting social action movements.

Paull, too, recognizes the element of conflict when he observes that social action refers to “those organised and planned activities that attempt to influence the social distribution of status, power and resources.”

Some scholars emphasize the use of ‘legally permissible’ methods while others state that the methods could be legal or not legal if the situation so warrants. Some state further that the objectives of social action may not necessarily be in conformity with culturally approved goals and values, especially when these are seen as major obstacles.

16.3 MAIN FEATURES

From the consideration of the definitions of social action, you may have got some idea about its features. We indicate them here although it is important to remember that not all forms of social action necessarily reflect them nor do all the authors agree that these are characteristic of social action.

- Social action is an organised effort directed at bringing about change in social, economic or political structures and in their style of functioning, in order to achieve social and economic well-being, specially of the under-privileged groups, and in bringing about a just social, economic and political order. It is perceived as a method of empowering the deprived through mobilization and collective action against vested interests and against exploitation by existing power groups (political groups, economic interests) and against exploitation by existing power groups (political groups, economic interests, industry, trade etc.).
- The field of social action cover a very wide spectrum – political reforms, social and economic reform, removal of social injustice and religious intolerance, restoration of human rights, enactment of legislation, sharing of power in decision making and in benefits, protection of the environment, liberation from the stranglehold of current mores, etc.
- The objectives of social action can be radical i.e., questioning the very foundation of current structures, and aiming at the overthrow and often proposing alternatives even if these have not been precisely worked out. At the other end, social action may work for changes within the existing system.

Voluntary Action

- Social action can be directed against global, universal issues like protection and conservation of environment through action, against its degradation, or on more localized issues like crime, sale of alcoholic drinks, wrongful use of village community resources by dominant individuals or groups, exploitation of labour, punishment of a wrong-doer, illegal felling of trees, etc. Even in the former case, social action programmes have to be specific and focused so that it is possible to mobilize support and organise pressure groups.
- The geographical area of social action and the numbers involved may be very large or relatively small depending on the issue.
- The driving force for social action may come from outside without initial sharing of the goals or strategies with the people being mobilized, or only partly sharing them. To achieve sustained results, however, involvement of the people in the goals and strategies is important.
- The goals of social action are not value neutral. They are value-oriented and normative in character, though these values and norms may at times be at variance with the culturally approved goals and values.
- Social action has elements of conflict, the resolution of which may not always be through peaceful and totally non-violent means even though violence may not be an explicitly propounded method.
- Social action may in some situations involve the use of methods or pursuit of goals which are wide in scope, more comprehensive and futuristic and may go beyond the law. However, social or moral legitimization of goals and methods is important.
- Social action movements require commitment of the leaders, their emotional involvement and belief in the goals and in the means used.
- Social action is not non-political. However, most of the social action movements are not initiated directly by political parties.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: a) Space is given below for your answers.

b) Compare your answers with the text.

- 1) In what ways would you consider Friendlander's definition of social action as inadequate for developing countries?

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2) List five features of social action.

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16.4 SOCIAL ACTION AND SOCIAL REFORMS

As a student you would be interested in knowing the difference between social action and social reform. You have some knowledge about social action. Let us first understand briefly the meaning of the term social reform.

Gore (1987) defined reform as “a deliberate effort to bring about a change in social attitudes, culturally defined role expectations and actual patterns of behaviour of people in a desired direction through processes of persuasion and public education”. He further observed that most social reform movements emanate from the “recognition of the dignity of the human individual and therefore, of the responsibility of the privileged to widen opportunities of life for all segments of the population.”

Let us now try and briefly state the common features of social action and social reforms:

- Both owe their beginning to dissatisfaction with existing systems or values and seek change in the direction of social justice. Both appeal to the ‘advantaged’ to accept the change in order to provide a better deal to the ‘disadvantaged’.
- Both follow a variety of strategies and tactics to achieve their goal, several of which are common.
- Both follow the method of mass mobilization.
- Both have normative ends.

Let us now see in what ways social action and social reform differ from each other:

- The scope of social action is much wider. Social reform is only one field of social action.
- Social reform represents a goal, at least an intermediate one, in the sense that through such reform, the status and situation of people affected will improve. Social action can be one of the means of achieving this goal.
- Social reform does not seek total alteration of economic, political and social structures nor does it reject them. It seeks amendments or changes

in specific aspects of them in order to humanize them. Social action could seek radical changes or even reject existing systems when it amounts to injustice, inequity, repression and exploitation.

- Social reform movements are a product of the times and its importance has varied in different periods of history. Social action has a place, relevance, and need at every stage of a society's development.
- The main actors in social reform may come from social and religious groups. Social action interests cut across different communities.
- An important objective of social reforms is to consolidate the change through legislation. In the case of social action, legislation may or may not become necessary as the objective may as well be achieved through non-legislative means.

16.5 STRATEGIES OF SOCIAL ACTION

There are different strategies of social action. The strategy determines the tactics used. Whatever the strategy, several steps are involved in organizing social action movements. Let us consider these aspects.

Types of Strategies

Various strategies and techniques of social action have been identified, some conceptually, others on the basis of analysis of actual movements. Gabriel Britto (1984) made an attempt to identify the strategies in the Gandhian model of mobilization for action. These are:

Credibility-building: This implies building of a good public image of the leadership, the sponsors and the participants based on cherished social values.

Legitimization: Promoting the movement's objectives as being morally right, and therefore the action is legitimate and permissible socially and morally.

Dramatization: This implies mobilizing the population into action through emotional appeals, soul-stirring speeches, management of the media, novel procedures of drawing support, catchy slogans, processions, protest marches and such other techniques.

Multiple strategies: This implies a concerted programme of action involving advocacy, education, persuasion, facilitating actions, pressure tactics etc.

Dual approach which implies building a counter system as an alternative or reviving a system which is declining, or has declined, but which is perceived to be beneficial. A constructive counter action plan is proposed which is in opposition to an existing system and perceived to be unjust, exploitative or undesirable.

Manifold programme: This implies developing social, economic and political programmes which would facilitate mass mobilization for social and economic reconstruction and political independence.

Siddiqui (1984) has mentioned the stages used in the Sarvodaya strategy drawing from the Sarvodaya social action movements inspired by the Gandhian philosophy. The stages are: (1) Prachar (Publicity) (2) Parichaya (Introduction) (3) Adhyayan (Survey or study) (4) Sahavasa (Association) (5) Seva (Service) (6) Pratikar (Resistance) (7) Construction Work or Community Service (8) Building the Climate of Change.

Stages 5 to 8 indicate that in the Gandhian approach constructive social service and peaceful non-violent ways of achieving change are basic. In fact, Gandhians strongly advocate 'constructive work'. This includes activities like relief work in emergencies such as floods, setting up basic education schools, the promotion of Khadi and other cottage industries and crafts, anti-liquor propaganda, and social work among the Harijans and the women.

Speaking about the non-violent social action model, Das Gupta (1984) observed: "Although non-violent social action also uses conflicts and struggles as weapons, its purpose is not to 'defeat' an enemy but to 'win' him over. The aim is not to crush an individual or to destroy an opponent however importantly placed he may be in a system, but to change the system and to protect the body and the psyche of the so called 'enemy' – both for his own good as also for the good whom the person opposes. Its aim is not to win only a struggle but to establish new values and norms that may pioneer the way to a new society. Means are ends in the non-violent battle and the ends are means. Since the two are equated in the structure of the method of non-violent action, the latter cannot, and does not, use ends to justify the means but harps on the need for adopting pure means for reaching pure goals."

Several scholars of social action point out that when non-violent technique for building pressure through mobilizing public opinion fails to alter the system or undo the injustice, some form of militancy and systematic expressions of hatred, anger, dislike, contempt, force (not necessarily violent) are perceived as necessary, even if it is in a limited way. Das Gupta (1987) refers to the "conflict cum non-violent model". He observes: "The adjective 'not non-violent' instead of the term 'violent' is deliberately chosen here as only a few of those who belong to the school of action would, even if they reject the non-violent model, agree to call their path the path of violence".

Let us now see how social work educators look at social action strategies. Desai (1984) has classified the strategies available to social workers into three categories:

- **Collaborative:** This is based on the assumption that people in power will agree to change even when a conflict approach is not adopted. Change can be brought about because "the intended change is either the lesser of

the two evils or they have themselves identified the factors which affect the very existence of the institution or the achievement of its goals; they are disenchanted, or dissatisfied and therefore willing to engage in the change effort though some part of the system may show initial resistance”.

- **Bargaining, Negotiating and Advocacy:** The assumption here is that since resistance is anticipated, some kind of mild pressure would be necessary. In the words of Desai: “These could include techniques of bargaining and negotiation, publicity which leads to discomfort for the target of change, advocacy through the media and attempts to isolate the target group from the opinions of the community at large. The techniques utilized may, to some extent, deviate from the usual interpersonal behaviours, and include methods such as satyagraha, morcha, and other methods of dramatizing the situation and developing public opinion”.
- **Conflictual/Confrontational:** The assumption here is that there are fundamental differences in positions and viewpoints and therefore strong pressure tactics become necessary (such as, for instance, demonstration and civil disobedience, or direct action). Since conflict in its more extreme manifestations could mean annihilation, elimination, defeat or subjugation, these have not been mentioned by Desai as possible tactics, probably because they are not in harmony with the educational philosophy of social work.

A somewhat similar classification of strategies of social action has been given by Lees (1972). He categorises them as:

- **Collaboration:** This is useful where, according to Lees, “there is basic agreement about the way an issue should be resolved or the likelihood of reaching such agreement once the issue is fully considered”.
- **Competition:** This is relevant where there is ‘conflict’ over interests but where it is possible for the contending parties to agree on the means to promote the different view-points. According to Lees this implies conflict over goals but consensus over means.
- **Disruption:** This occurs when there are little chances of reaching an agreement and the tactics used may vary from “peaceful demonstration to revolutionary upheavals”.

Whatever the classification, it is important to remember that the different strategies do not comprise water-tight compartments. Nor do they represent an orderly movement from the peaceful to the disruptive strategies. Sometimes the conflict model is adopted when the other models fail. Sometimes even if one model is applied, the approaches of the other models are selectively used.

Tactics

From the definitions of social action and the discussion of the strategies, you have seen that social action involves the use of a variety of tactics – often a combination of them – depending on the philosophy and ideological beliefs of the sponsors, the techniques used by the other party, and the dynamics of the situation as it develops.

Some of the tactics have been explicitly identified and are listed below:

- Fact finding,
- Publicity, advocacy, dissemination, using both formal and nonformal media,
- Education, awareness-building, conscientisation,
- Mobilizing support and opinion through established institutional systems and political processes,
- Expressing anger, wrath, hatred in dramatic and innovative ways,
- Cooperation/collabouration,
- Using slogans,
- Negotiation, bargaining, arbitration,
- Disruption and mild coercion (mild resistance, protests, marches, morcha, dharna, strikes, boycotts, fasts, gherao etc.) defiance of orders and various forms of economic sanctions.
- Strong coercive tactics (extra-legal measures, and direct action).

The choice of tactics is conditioned by the choice of strategy. Though confrontation and conflict are inherent in social action, most social activists would like to abstain from violence and seek resolution of the conflict and change by building moral and public pressure. Most of the social action is also not directed towards the overthrow of the system but rather its humanization.

Steps

As you must have realized by now, certain steps are involved in social action. These are enumerated here:

- 1) Identifying the problem (in this case injustice), diagnosing it, gathering information about it and about who the principal actors are, what roles they play, what interests they have and what benefits they derive.
- 2) Determining the position to be taken.
- 3) Identifying the social action goals i.e. the expected outcomes. These should be specific and at least some should be tangible.
- 4) Mobilizing support using both non formal and formal methods and locating the networks of influence and power.

- 5) Setting up the machinery to carry out the struggle, canvas action, provide leadership.
- 6) Laying down the strategy. A well-drawn out plan indicating series of actions and their networking among the leaders.
- 7) Laying down the communication channels and the decision-making loci of the social action movement.
- 8) Carrying out the action.
- 9) Reviewing the implementation of the strategy and, if necessary, weighing alternative approaches and working out alternate plans.
- 10) Sustaining the pressure.

Some writers by the above mentioned steps have suggested the stages as:

- 1) **Awareness-building** (Steps 1 and 2)
- 2) **Organising people** (Steps 3, 4, and 5)
- 3) **Developing the strategy** (Steps 6 and 7)
- 4) **Action** (Steps 8, 9 and 10)

Check Your Progress 2

Note: a) Space is given below for your answers.

b) Compare your answers with the text.

- 1) In what ways does the strategy in the Gandhian model of social action differ from others?

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Activity I

Identify a social action issue (even a hypothetical one) and draw up two action plans. Base the first one on the Gandhian model and the second on other models.

16.6 SOCIAL ACTION IN INDIA

India has been the place of many social action movements. Let us briefly mention some of them.

Satyagraha is a uniquely Indian concept and mode of social action shaped into a formidable tool by Mahatma Gandhi. Although based on non-violence

(since Gandhi believed and practiced ahimsa and considered it a powerful tool), satyagraha meant exerting moral pressure, through mass mobilization, mass courting of arrests, and long protest marches to achieve the goal. We mention here some examples.

The Rowlatt Act Satyagraha: What is popularly known as the Rowlatt Act (1918) represented an attempt to put war time restrictions on civil rights and detentions without trial for a maximum period of two years. All sections of Indian political opinion vehemently opposed the Rowlatt Act but it was left to Mahatma Gandhi to work out a practicable all-India mass protest. The intention was to go beyond petitions but at the same time to stop it from being unrestrained or violent. Initially, the volunteers merely courted arrest by publicly selling prohibited literature. It was then extended by Mahatma Gandhi to include the idea of an all India Hartal (strike).

The Salt Satyagraha: Mahatma Gandhi's famous Dandi March symbolized protest against the government monopoly of salt and the claim to salt tax. The march which started from Sabarmati to the sea through the heartland of Gujarat attracted considerable attention both within India and outside. Mahatma Gandhi propagated manufacture and auctioning of salt by the people violating the unjust law. This action was accompanied by boycott of foreign cloth and liquor.

The Nagpur Flag Satyagraha: This was started in mid 1923 against a local order banning the use of the Congress flag in some areas of the city.

The Borsad (Kheda district, Gujarat) Satyagraha: This was directed against a poll tax imposed to be paid by every adult for the police required to suppress a wave of dacoities. The movement took the form of total non-payment of the new levy by all the 104 affected villages and the tax had to be withdrawn.

The Vaikom Satyagraha: This was the first temple entry movement. It was essentially an attempt on Gandhi an lines to assert the right of low caste Ezhavas and untouchables to use roads near a Travancore temple. Gandhi an social action has to be understood in the context of the Gandhian philosophy of work which aimed at building a social and economic order based on non-violence, and building the strength of the people and the moral fabric. It included not only activities like relief work in emergencies but also setting up basic education schools, the promotion of khadi and other cottage crafts, anti-liquor propaganda, uplift of the lower castes and untouchables.

Chetna' march in Panchmahal and Sabrakantha districts of Gujarat: This was organised by DISHA (a voluntary organisation) which, on analysis of its programmes, came to the conclusion that unless awareness is created among the forest labourers, minor forest produce collectors, small community action groups and other agencies working in the area, the injustices and exploitation would continue and the affected people would not come forward to lodge their complaints, narrate their grievances and seek redressal. One of

the methods devised by DISHA to generate awareness was to organise a foot march in the area which covered nearly 1000 km. through the most backward districts.

Mahila Mukti Morcha – Dalli Rajhara: Dalli Rajhara is an iron ore mining town in the southern Durg district in Madhya Pradesh. The mines here are largely worked manually through contractors. Contract labourers are mainly members of Adivasi, landless and small peasant households from the seven districts of Chhattisgarh in eastern Madhya Pradesh.

The women took a leading role in organising social action struggles. For example, in 1979-80, the wages of the workers improved after a successful struggle. A successful anti-alcoholism campaign was carried out on the ground that it drained hard won benefits back into the pockets of the contractors and liquor merchants. The mass mobilization achieved among the households was a rare example of mobilization on a social issue. Women played a leading role in propagating the philosophy of this campaign, and in organising mohalla committees, for detection and punishment. In 1982 the women started their own forum called Mahila Mukti Morcha (MMM). The forum concentrated on three broad areas of concern – women and work, women and health and women's struggles. Action arising out of MMM platform was largely issue-based. Awareness and mobilization were effected through a variety of methods including plays and songs, and through annual observation of martyrdom of those who had struggled for the rights of the poor.

Narmada Bachao and Holan is a social action movement which has brought together several organisations engaged in developmental issues, for the environmental problems caused by the construction of the Narmada Dam. The movement today enjoys widespread support, cutting across different segments of the population, apart from people directly affected by the construction of the dam. The movement is spearheaded by eminent social workers, scientists, intellectuals, students and the local villagers. Huge protest marches have been organised in which villagers from far and near, from different states, have participated with banners, shouting slogans, sporting badges forming a human chain on the banks of the Narmada in protest, taking pledges, organizing demonstrations at the dam site, and often violating prohibitory orders. Its defiant message from the people to decision makers and planners is for full participation at all the levels of planning and that the people are no longer prepared to watch in mute desperation, as projects after projects are approved without ensuring that the benefits accrue mainly to the people and are not cornered by the vested interests like the 'contractor and the rich'.

16.7 LET US SUM UP

You have seen in this unit that social action represents an organised attempt of the people to secure a more humane society. It is a powerful instrument to empower the poor and to secure social justice and human rights. It seeks changes in an unjust social and economic order or in unjust actions. You also saw that while some scholars were of the view that social action should be confined to seeking the goals within the existing social, economic and political frame work and accepted methods of seeking change, others were of the view that the methods could be legal, or not so legal if the situation so warrants, especially when legally permissible methods fail. Social action may also not always be in conformity with current social and cultural values of dominant groups in society, especially when they are seen as major obstacles. The social and moral contents of the action give it the necessary social and moral legitimacy. The goals of social action are not value-neutral. You read about the various strategies of social action, including the Gandhian Model. You learnt about different ways of classifying the strategies of social action and the tactics that are used. You also read about the step in social action for awareness building, mobilization and organising people, laying down strategies and carrying out action. Finally you read about some of the social action movements in India.

16.8 KEY WORDS

Dharna: Picketing.

Gherao: A coercive action in which workers/others agitating for the acceptance of their demands, encircle those in decision-making positions for longer hours to force them to agree.

Morcha: The term literally means organisation of a front (as would be the case of the foremost line of the army against the enemy) to fight for their rights or for an issue of wider social concern.

Satyagraha: Struggle for truth using non-violent means. This was developed into a formidable tool by Mahatma Gandhi through mass mobilization and exertion of moral pressure to undo injustice and exploitation.

16.9 SUGGESTED READINGS

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